



coach, train a range of athletes at varied levels and challenge yourself in unorthodox settings. A master coach is someone who has produced results consistently over time at various locations, with various athletes, at various ages and stages of development.

Where theory meets practice there lies success. Talking theory till the cows come home may be good for a classroom presentation, but practical application needs to be innovative according to the skill, athlete, situation, and needs. There seems to be a huge missing link here.

Ground contact positions are static

Foot strike is entirely velocity-dependent. Sprinting mechanics and foot strike velocity to the ground are totally different from walking, so why are athletes still taught running mechanics drills at walking speed? The ball-of-the-foot paradigm is baffling. Where is the adaptation?

More is better

Many athletes seldom know how much is enough because they have

always done too much. It's the critical job of the coach to be a caretaker rather than a slave driver. Similarly, some athletes have limited concentration capacity. Avoid being redundant in both communication and loading principles. What we say, and how we say it, matters a lot in effective implementation. As coaches, the words we use are like sets and reps — they must serve the purpose they are designed for.

Cues are fixed

Cues have a validity period and are like food — you need to change them often in line with the needs of an athlete specific to skills and other requirements. For example, some athletes feel the muscle working in a particular angle and range, while others do not — cue accordingly. Communicate in a way that makes sense to your athletes, not just in a way that makes sense to you.

Coaching is all about the sets and reps

Athletes are the ultimate performance variable, not your programme. Empathy is one of the

Foot strike conundrum: Sprinting mechanics and foot strike velocity to the ground are totally different from walking, so why are athletes still taught running mechanics drills at walking speed? The ball-of-the-foot paradigm is baffling. GETTY IMAGES

greatest qualities a coach can have — it is not a weakness. The job of a coach is to connect people with purpose first, without ulterior motives. Focusing merely on the science and workload will not produce championship-winning performances.

Target weaknesses over strengths

Strengths are what make an athlete great and lead to winning. Focusing solely on their weaknesses can impede confidence and annihilate performance. Gradual progression, adaptation protocols, and benchmarks are much more influential than rigid timeframe setting — never rush to 'clear' weaknesses. Keep strengths really strong and progressively address weaknesses through proper processes and protocols.

You need world-class facilities to succeed

This is a total misnomer. Time and time again, athletes have set and broken world records that once seemed humanly impossible. Many of these athletes have never been to a sports science centre or trained at cutting-edge facilities.

This is a false excuse for underperformance and avoiding responsibility for failure. People use facilities as an excuse when, in reality, it is a failure of creativity. I have personally seen athletes thrive in world-class scenarios without proper access to facilities, nutrition, or other paraphernalia.

Having sports science is an excellent tool for peak performance, but many athletes have also proven otherwise. There is a saying in Tamil: for a mighty warrior, even a blade of grass is a deadly weapon to strike or defend.